

Gambling with Your Life

Gambling may seem like an easy way to make a quick buck, but rarely are the consequences of not winning the bet considered. Once you fall into debt, you may find yourself gambling more money to try and recover your losses or even engaging in something illegal to pay your losses back. Take, for example, a player from the Arizona State basketball team who pleaded guilty to conspiracy to commit sports bribery. It started when Stevin “Hedake” Smith sunk himself more than \$10,000 in debt to a student bookie. To wash the debt, Smith agreed to shave points off several games. Smith then enlisted the help of a teammate.

When more than \$1 million in bets were placed on several games in Las Vegas, the FBI became suspicious. The setup was traced to organized crime in Chicago. Smith and his teammate were arrested and convicted of sports bribery.

Sports wagering is not the only type of gambling that young people are engaged in, but the pattern is consistent no matter what type of gambling is chosen. A recent study by the Annenberg Public Policy Center found that monthly card-game gambling among young people was up 20 percent from the year before, and 57 percent of the young men surveyed said they gambled at least once a month.

The popularity of gambling would lead one to believe that this is a highly profitable venture. However, the odds are that you will lose more than you will win. To recover your losses, you continue to gamble and a vicious cycle ensues. It is very difficult to break this cycle, as the case history of Felix reveals.

All of Felix’s friends were envious of his success. Only two years out of medical school, it seemed that he had everything while they were still struggling. Felix had a loving wife, his own medical practice, a beautiful home, and a luxury car. On top of it all, he seemed content with his life. Whereas some

